SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #41 · SALVATION

“I am saved by my good works.”

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Where it often comes from

Believing that good people go to heaven and bad people do not. Being taught that church attendance, giving, or service earns God’s favor. A home where love was earned by performance. Comparing yourself with others who seem worse. Never clearly hearing the gospel of grace.

What Scripture teaches

Salvation is a gift of God’s grace received through faith in Jesus, not a reward for good works. God saved us not because of righteous things we had done, but because of His mercy. No one is justified by keeping rules. Good works still matter: we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works. But they are the fruit of salvation, not the root of it.

> *“For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast”* **(Ephesians 2:8–9)**.

Also see

> “He saved us, not by the righteous deeds we had done, but according to His mercy, through the washing of new birth and renewal by the Holy Spirit” **(Titus 3:5)**.

> “Know that a man is not justified by works of the law, but by faith in Jesus Christ. So we, too, have believed in Christ Jesus, that we may be justified by faith in Christ and not by works of the law, because by works of the law no one will be justified” **(Galatians 2:16)**.

> “However, to the one who does not work, but believes in Him who justifies the wicked, his faith is credited as righteousness” **(Romans 4:5)**.

> “For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life” **(Ephesians 2:10)**.

Common self-statements

- I’m a good person, so God will accept me.
- If my good deeds outweigh my bad ones, I’ll be fine.
- I have to keep doing more to be saved.
- God owes me for all I’ve done.
- I’m better than most people, so I’m safe.
- If I stop serving, I’ll lose my salvation.

Common logical errors

- **Comparison:** Measuring yourself against other people instead of God’s holiness.
- **Scorekeeping:** Treating salvation like a balance of good and bad deeds.
- **Pride:** Believing your goodness earns God’s acceptance.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Working harder out of fear rather than gratitude.

Challenging questions

- What does Ephesians 2:8–9 say salvation is: a wage or a gift?
- How many good works would be enough to make up for one sin?
- If I could earn salvation, why did Jesus need to die?
- Am I comparing myself to people or to God’s holiness?
- Do I serve God out of love, or to keep my place with Him?
- What does Ephesians 2:10 say good works are for?
- Have I ever simply received Christ as my Savior?

Truth summary

> I am not saved by my good works. I am saved by God’s grace through faith in Jesus Christ. Salvation is a gift, not something I earn. Because I am saved, I want to do good works out of gratitude and love, as God’s workmanship in Christ.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- **Salvation**
- **Grace**
- **Faith**
- **Christ, Sacrifice of**
- **Pride**

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Jesus Paid It All — Kristian Stanfill (Passion)
The refrain says Jesus paid it all, so there is nothing left for my good works to pay.

Amazing Grace (My Chains Are Gone) — Chris Tomlin
Salvation is pictured as a gift that sets us free, not a wage we earn.

Nothing but the Blood — Reawaken Hymns
Asks what can wash away sin and answers: nothing but the blood of Jesus.

Not What My Hands Have Done — Aaron Keyes
Names what our own efforts cannot do and points to Christ alone.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing “I am saved by my good works”

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

“I am saved by my good works.” I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Is salvation a wage or a gift?
- ☐ How many good deeds would make up for one sin?
- ☐ If I could earn it, why did Jesus die?
- ☐ Am I comparing myself to people or to God?
- ☐ Do I serve from love or from fear?
- ☐ Have I simply received Christ?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am saved by grace through faith.
- ☐ Salvation is God’s gift, not my wage.
- ☐ God saved me because of His mercy.
- ☐ Good works are the fruit of salvation, not the root.
- ☐ I serve God out of gratitude, not to earn His love.
- ☐ I am God’s workmanship in Christ.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Ephesians 2:8–9**
  “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast.”
- [ ] **Titus 3:5**
  “He saved us, not by the righteous deeds we had done, but according to His mercy, through the washing of new birth and renewal by the Holy Spirit.”
- [ ] **Galatians 2:16**
  “Know that a man is not justified by works of the law, but by faith in Jesus Christ. So we, too, have believed in Christ Jesus, that we may be justified by faith in Christ and not by works of the law, because by works of the law no one will be justified.”
- [ ] **Romans 4:5**
  “However, to the one who does not work, but believes in Him who justifies the wicked, his faith is credited as righteousness.”
- [ ] **Ephesians 2:10**
  “For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life.”

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Listen to one song each day** from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Gift log:** Each day, write one thing I did for God, then write: "Not to earn, but because I am loved."
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Ephesians 2:8–9 becomes: "For it is by grace **Sarah** has been saved through faith, and this not from **herself**; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The **"Salvation" topic in Pearls**.
- ☐ **Listening:** The **Overcoming Anxiety audio** by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write down every good thing you hope will get you to heaven,** then write across it: "Saved by grace, through faith, as a gift."
- ☐ **Pray a simple prayer receiving Christ as your Savior,** or thanking Him again if you already have.
- ☐ **Do one good deed in secret this week** purely out of thanks to God, and tell no one.
- ☐ **Read Romans 3:21–28,** and write in your own words how a person is made right with God.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I am saved by my good works": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One good deed done from gratitude
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I am saved by my good works.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that salvation is Your free gift through Jesus Christ. Help me reject the lie that I am saved by my good works. I trust in Christ alone. Let my good works flow from gratitude, not fear, as I live as Your workmanship. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.